UNIT 2 · CHAPTER 10 · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Backlash & Broken Promises

How the revolution of Reconstruction was rolled back — by terror, by exhaustion, and by a bargain in a back room. 1870–1877.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

How the revolution of Reconstruction was rolled back — by terror, by exhaustion, and by a bargain in a back room. 1870–1877.

How was Reconstruction defeated — and was it a failure, or an unfinished revolution?

The Klan Rises

TERROR AS POLITICS

As Black men voted and held office, white Southerners determined to restore the old order struck back. They formed the Ku Klux Klan and groups like it, and used murder, whippings, and arson to drive Black voters — and their white Republican allies — out of politics.

This was not random crime. It was organized political violence, aimed squarely at destroying the new biracial democracy at the ballot box and in the night.

Grant Strikes Back

1870–1871

For a time, Washington fought back hard. The Enforcement Acts made Klan terror a federal crime, and President Grant sent in troops and federal prosecutors who arrested hundreds and, in places, broke the Klan outright.

It showed what was possible: when the federal government chose to protect Black citizenship with real force, it could. The question was whether the North would keep choosing to.

Colfax

1873

The violence never truly stopped. In 1873, at Colfax, Louisiana, a white mob attacked Black men defending a courthouse and killed scores of them — many after they had surrendered. It was the deadliest single day of Reconstruction.

Worse, the Supreme Court later used the case to gut the federal laws meant to punish such violence — ruling that Washington could not reach crimes committed by individuals. The legal shield over Black citizens was cracking.

Losing the Will

THE NORTH LOOKS AWAY

Northern resolve was draining away. The Panic of 1873 plunged the country into a deep depression, and voters cared far more about jobs and railroads than about the South.

Many Northerners had simply grown tired of the “Southern question.” One by one, white Democrats “redeemed” the Southern states — retaking control as federal attention drifted elsewhere.

Redemption

1869–1877

State by state, white Democrats retook the South — and the federal government let them.

The fall of Reconstruction, state by state. Darker shades mark later “redemption”; the last three states held out until the bargain of 1877. · Map © ShadowDog Digital Studios

The Clock Runs Out

STATE BY STATE

Between 1869 and 1877, every single ex-Confederate state fell back under the control of white Democrats determined to erase the gains of Reconstruction.

As each state was “redeemed,” Black voters were pushed from the rolls, Black officeholders driven out, and the promises of the Fourteenth and Fifteenth Amendments left unenforced — alive on paper, dead in practice.

The Deal in the Back Room

1877

The 1876 presidential election was a disputed mess. In the Compromise of 1877, Republicans were handed the White House (Rutherford B. Hayes) in exchange for a promise: pull the last federal troops out of the South.

With the soldiers gone, the final Reconstruction governments collapsed within weeks. The federal government had, in effect, abandoned the freedpeople to their former masters.

The Long Shadow

THE PROMISE BROKEN

What rose in Reconstruction's place became known as Jim Crow: legal segregation, the stripping of the Black vote, and systems of control like sharecropping debt and convict leasing — the last so brutal that one historian called it “worse than slavery.”

The great amendments were not repealed. They lay dormant — a set of promises written into the Constitution, waiting nearly a century for a new generation to finally demand that the nation keep them.

FREDERICK DOUGLASS · 1857

Power concedes nothing without a demand. It never did and it never will.

Eight Investigations

YOUR TURN

How was a revolution undone — and was it truly defeated, or only deferred? Step into the terror, the politics, and the broken promises of Reconstruction's last years.